

demoralising but I think that as a community we are just so obsessed with housing,' Unkles says. 'What can a first home buyer do if they feel as if it is racing away? Do what you can – don't get obsessed with what you can't.'

3. An established apartment, townhouse or unit

Must have: Direct public transport access to the city.

Why? You are compromising on land but gaining enviable location.

Suburbs with a lower volume of apartments and townhouses will provide a degree of safeguard against oversupply (which is a contentious topic itself, depending on which property or economy boffin you ask about whether this exists, and where). That aside, the scarcity factor helps to preserve, as best as possible, the value of your purchase. Scarcity buoys prices – like any limited edition goods, the fewer there are the more valuable, and the same goes for real estate.

Look for a townhouse or apartment that offers what the rest of the market doesn't; it might be in the zone for an excellent government school, have views that no other location can boast – more than just 'CBD vistas', which have become a dime a dozen – or a comfortable floorplan.

If you want lifestyle foremost, and are happy to have more gentle capital growth than land provides, there is no harm in seeking an apartment over a house. You'll be able to buy much closer to town and the cost of public transport against running a car, for one, will be kinder on your wallet.

Embracing apartment life

Brad Swartz is proof that the Great Australian Dream has shrunk in scale. The Sydney-based architect lives in a 27-square-metre apartment in the inner-eastern enclave of Darlinghurst. There isn't room to swing a cat, but Swartz has got the cream; his micro-home was judged Australia's best apartment at the 2015 Houses Awards. (Swartz also won best emerging practice at the 2017 Australian Interior Design Awards.) For him, an apartment need not be a